examine me on what my team did for five years in Vernon. And, to do that, you should be experts in liquid propulsion.'

I might have sounded, as usual, haughty, but my intention was not to run down anyone, leave alone Kalam, who despite his love for solid propulsion, did not fail to see the merits of dedication and hard work.

'Now, let me explain what we did,' I continued. 'And you can shoot your questions.'

For the next hour or so I addressed the meeting, virtually like a lecturer in an engineering classroom. Now I called my team heads, one by one, to give details of what and how we learned about the technology, fabrication and assembly procedure, besides the drawings, documents and experiment reports we have.

Mohana Prasad started with the turbo pump. After each session by a team leader, there were questions. My team had ready answers for everything, but it irritated me that many of the queries were basic stuff, which have already been circulated as a document to everyone at the meeting. When there seemed to be no end to mundane clarifications, I interfered.

'Gentlemen, you seem to be having a good education here, but does anyone have a question that tests more than our memory power?' I said.

It was not a pleasant interjection.

Coming out of that meeting, Kalam threw his hand around my shoulder.

'Buddy,' he said, 'this is a learning process for all of us, don't get agitated.'

'Kalam,' I replied, 'I can't be as diplomatic as you. You know there are many people here who will find a hundred reasons to reject the Vikas engine without knowing a thing about it.'

'Wait for the report,' said Kalam, smiling. And he walked away.

The committee gave a report that said something to this effect: it appears that the technology relating to fabrication and realisation of a liquid propulsion engine has been achieved by the team to a great extent. However, only when we make a prototype would we know the exact level of expertise the team has acquired.

It was not a bad report, but I still argued what was the need for such a committee when all it could say is that it has to be done to be believed. I, however, turned this ambiguity in the report to my advantage: Now that the committee has found that ultimate validation will come only from fabricating, we need to build a prototype of Vikas.